Barrel Fever

By David Sedaris

ADOLPH: **(Pg 126-150)** My mother was in the hospital, recovering from surgery to remove cancerous lymph nodes. The cancer was nothing compared to the punishment she endured from her roommate, Mrs. Gails. The woman never said a word but watched television constantly at top volume.

MOTHER: *(loudly, fidgeting with a bracelet on her wrist)* You got any questions about the grazing habits of the North American bull moose? I complained to the nurses about the volume but all they do is point to their ears and whisper that she's got a hearing problem. If she's got such a hearing problem then why are they whispering about her? She can hear the food cart from down the hall. *(perks up and rubs her hands together)* I want that woman dead. *(changing the subject)* Did I tell you that your sister Charity called me? I hardly recognized her voice because it's been, what, three years since she's phoned me. It seems she lost her job

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at the suicide hot line and is looking to borrow some money. I said, "Hold on just a few seconds, darling. It's a bit difficult to reach my purse with this IV in my arm."

INTRODUCTION

In Adolph's world, family bonding looks a lot like emotional dodgeball—everyone lobbing sarcasm, guilt, and questionable gifts at each other just to see who flinches first. His mother, a woman powered almost entirely by complaints and cafeteria Jell-O, turns her hospital room into a full-volume comedy special, starring herself and co-starring anyone unlucky enough to wander in. Mom . . . the gift that keeps on giving – may she rest in . . . well, never mind.

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MOTHER: *(on the phone)* Did I tell you what your sister Hope sent me for my birthday? A poncho. Who does she think I am that I might want a poncho? I've written her back saying I'm sure it will come in very handy the next time I mount my burro for the three-day journey over the mountains to the neighboring village. I've thrown it into the garage-sale box along with the pepper grinder Joy sent me. The thing is two feet long, black and shiny – what do I need with a thing like that? It doesn't take a psychiatrist to recognize the pepper

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grinder for what it truly is. I bet she spent weeks knocking that one around with her therapist. But that's Joy for you, thinking she can impress people with the money she makes 'consulting.' That's what she calls herself now, a consultant, as if that means anything. Anyone who answers questions can call themselves a consultant. A telephone operator is a consultant, a palm reader: they're all consultants. I thought I'd seen it all but then Faith sent me a subscription to that trade paper she's working for. She calls it a magazine. Why would anyone subscribe to a magazine devoted to adobe? Is this a big trend? I've got a house made of bricks but who wants to read about it every month? Adobe? She circled her name on the first page where she's listed as 'Features Editor.' When people ask what she's up to I always tell them she's a secretary – it sounds better. So then, a week after my birthday I got a call from your sister Charity . . .

ADOLPH: Faith, Hope, Joy, Charity, and me, Adolph. See, she just couldn't help herself.

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ADOLPH: On the afternoon of my last visit, my mother handed me a check for forty thousand dollars and warned me to cash it fast. Mrs. Gails's television was blaring a rerun of a vile situation comedy in which a pleasant-looking, vapid teenaged boy acts as the game-keeper of four terminally precocious children.

MOTHER: Leave. *(pointing to the door)* And on your way out I want you to shut off her television. It'll take the nurses a good twenty minutes to turn it back on. Give me the gift of peace. It's worth the forty thousand dollars, believe me.

ADOLPH: As I left the room she offered to double the money if I smothered Mrs. Gails.

MOTHER: Use the pillow . . . The pillow.

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ADOLPH: [And then she died] Three days after the memorial service we met with her lawyer, an energetic woman with very long fingernails painted to resemble American flags. She informed us that my mother's house, car, and personal possessions were to be sold at their current market value. That money would be added to her life insurance, pension plan, and bank

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holdings and, according to her will, would be donated to her specified charitable organization, The National Rifle Association.

After the initial shock had worn off, my sisters found themselves [with] plenty more to talk about. I didn't mention the money (the 40 thousand dollars) . . . like my mother, I may be mean but I'm not stupid.

Shortly after my mother died, my sisters and I found ourselves rummaging through a cabinet of papers marked "POISON," and it was there, tucked between the pages of a well-worn copy of Mein Kampf, that I discovered fifteen years' worth of her annual New Year's resolutions. She took up the practice the same year she bought her first rifle. Every Christmas afternoon, after placing the artificial tree back into its box, she would grow reflective.

MOTHER: Was it wrong of me to spit on that Jehovah's Witness girl? Tell me the truth here. I need a second opinion.

ADOLPH: On New Year's Eve she would sit with her notes and a coffee cup of champagne, glancing at her watch

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and tapping a pencil against the legs of her chair. She would write something on an index card and, moments later, shake her head and erase it. The process was repeated until she wore a hole through the card and was forced to start fresh on another. The next morning I would ask, "So, what was on your list, Mom?"

MOTHER: Smother those homely teenagers who call themselves my children is at the top.

ADOLPH: I always got a great kick out of my mother, but my sisters, for one reason or another, failed to get the joke. They have grown to be humorless and clinically sensitive: the sorts of people who overuse the words "rage" and "empowerment" and constantly ask, "What do you really mean by that?" While I would often call and visit our mother, they kept their distance, limiting their postal or telephone contact to the holidays.

Following her death my sisters were horrified to discover, sealed in boxes, every gift they had given her.

FAITH: How could she not want a first edition by M. Scott Peck?

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HOPE: I made these wind chimes with my own two hands. Didn't that count for anything?

JOY: What did she have against pepper grinders?

ADOLPH: Aside from a few stiff wallets fashioned in summer camp, there was nothing of mine in those boxes as, at an early age, I discovered that postage stamps, cartons of cigarettes, light bulbs, and mail-order steaks are the gifts that keep giving.

"How could she possibly be so cruel?" my sisters asked, coming upon the unmailed notes and letters stored in the "POISON" file.

JOY: *(holding a draft of her graduation card)* I am not the 'missing link,' I am not, I am not. I am not 'God's gift to fraternity beer baths,' I am not, I am not, I am not.

ADOLPH: Charity and Faith gathered round and the three of them embraced in a circle of healing. There were letters to me, but in all honesty it really didn't bother me too much. We all entertain hateful thoughts every now and then. My mother hadn't mailed those letters; she simply left them to be discovered after her death. Hey, at least she was thinking about us.

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The most shocking discovery in the box marked "POISON" were not her letters, but the stack of New Year's resolutions she'd spent so long composing. Each of the fifteen cards was dated in the left-hand corner and, in her slanted, childlike writing, each one read the same: "Be good." It shook me up as, in the three years that I myself have been making such lists, mine say the same thing, relatively. I have taken to softening my approach as a safeguard against failure. The last one reads: "Try to think about maybe being good." "Try" and "maybe" give me the confidence I need in order to maintain the casual approach best suited to my ever-changing circumstances.

[So here I was looking] at my telephone and [telling] myself that I would (wait) until someone called, at which point I would answer and redirect my life. Whoever they were and whatever they wanted, I would take it as a sign. *(beat)* The phone didn't ring until sometime around ten in the evening. It was a woman's voice and she started in immediately saying. . .

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TRUDY: All right now, I realize you probably don't remember who I am, do you? It's me, Trudy Chase. I used to be Trudy Cousins. Chase is my married name even though I'm no longer married if that makes any sense! Anyway, I read the obituary on your mother. I know it's been a while but I just wanted to tell you that I'm very sorry to hear about it.

ADOLPH: I didn't know how to respond.

TRUDY: You really don't remember me, do you? It's me, crazy Trudy who used to sit beside you in Mr. Pope's senior English class. Remember me? I was the crazy one. I was the one who wrote 'Don't follow me – I'm lost too' on the back of her graduation gown. It's me, crazy Trudy.

ADOLPH: *(to audience)* Suddenly I remembered her perfectly. Even at eighteen she struck me as hopeless. *(to Trudy)* So, Trudy, what's going on?

TRUDY: Oh, you know me. I'm just as crazy as ever. No, I take that back – I'm probably crazier if you can believe that!

ADOLPH: *(to audience)* Trudy went on to tell me that she's lived in Manhattan for three months, having been

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transferred from the home office in Piedmont. She chuckled, adding that the people here think she's just about the craziest person they've ever met. She's so crazy that she planned an office party for Lincoln's birthday and petitioned her boss to free the slaves in the accounting department. And she even wore a tall hat and a fake beard! The members of her tenant's association thought she should be committed after she hosted the last meeting . . . by candlelight! *(to Trudy)* Ha, ha. That sounds pretty scary.

TRUDY: Nothing scares me. That's how crazy I am.

ADOLPH: Nothing?

TRUDY: Not a damned thing. Nada. Othing-nay.

ADOLPH: The very idea that, out of nowhere, a member of my 1975 graduating class would call me and speak pig Latin created a mixed sense of repulsion and endless possibilities.

Trudy spoke of her involvement in any number of organizations. She is, for example, volunteering to walk the dogs of recent stroke victims.

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TRUDY: I usually walk with a woman named Marcie, and, Jesus, if you think I'm crazy, you should meet her! We call ourselves the Poop Troop, and next week we're getting our uniforms. You should join us sometime.

ADOLPH: I pictured myself wearing an "I brake for hydrants" T-shirt and a baseball cap decorated with a synthetic stool.

On top of everything else Trudy also finds the time to play on her company volleyball team, iron for her crazy arthritic neighbor, and teach underprivileged children to make fudge. She didn't say it in a boastful way. She wasn't looking for a medal or trying to make me feel selfish. She invited me over to her apartment for a get-together, but I bowed out, claiming I had a business meeting to attend.

TRUDY: Well, if your meetings are half as crazy as mine you're going to need all the luck you can get," she said.

ADOLPH: She asked if she could call me after my meeting and I told her to hold a moment as I had another call coming in. She's been holding for fifteen minutes now and I still can't make up my mind. I look over at my

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mother's card on the refrigerator. BE GOOD. But she never specified: Be good to whom? If I'm good to Trudy Chase, I'll tell her never to call me again. If I'm good to myself, I'll wind up making fudge and walking the dogs of stroke victims. Which is worse?

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